

broke her celibacy and endangered the health of the city would be put to death. Since it was forbidden to spill the blood of a Vestal, she was buried alive in an underground chamber. Notably, only ten convictions for unchastity were recorded during the Roman Republic, including a Vestal named Marcia in 114 BCE. All such convictions took place during periods of crisis in the Roman state.

For their devotion to the city, Vestal virgins were awarded privileges, including the power to free slaves or imprisoned men simply by touching them. Throughout the Roman Republic, Vestal Virgins enjoyed rights that were not open to single women of a similar social status, and free from male guardianship were allowed to manage their own property. The Vestals were disbanded in 394 CE by the Christian Emperor Theodosius I, who also extinguished the fire.

**"IF YOU ALLOW  
[WOMEN] TO ACHIEVE ...  
EQUALITY ... THEY  
WILL BE ... MASTERS."**

CATO THE ELDER, AS RECORDED BY LIVY, *HISTORY OF ROME*

#### ▼ School of Vesta

The priestesses of Vesta held an exalted status in ancient Rome's state religion. Their lives were seen to be spiritually tied to the fate and health of the city itself.

